The breadth and intensity of cooperation over the last decade has been truly impressive. It is, of course, driven by much more frequent engagement at the leadership level, and by more comfortable conversations. This is supported at the cabinet and sub-cabinet levels through regular interactions on a wider scale. New mechanisms and dialogues have sprung up in every field of activity. Foundational agreements, contemporary frameworks and a larger volume of activity are all part of the change. And wherever that is quantifiable, trade, investments, students, visas, exchanges, the numbers tell their own story.

What started as an evolutionary exercise with a limited objective has not only mushroomed rapidly but is now developing increasingly higher levels of ambition. From the bilateral and regional agendas, ties have matured to cover a broader canvas and a more complex agenda. That the two nations are partnering each other in quadrilateral and trilateral groupings is a statement of how far their relations have come.

It is particularly notable that this growth enjoys strong societal support. There is, of course, the Indian diaspora factor in the US and the Congressional support. Because so much of the relationship is driven by so many constituencies of civil society, it can also be effervescent at times. Today, the strength of the bilateral ties encourages the two nations to work together beyond the narrower confines of their national interest.

Even as this unfolds, India and the US will also have to recognize that they approach the world from different vantage points, histories, culture and levels of development. From an Indian perspective, the US as a global power can, on occasion, have interests that are in contradiction with its own. Nor may it always share our priorities and perspectives. This naturally will be mirror imaged on the American side as well, especially as India’s influence and footprint expands. It is, therefore, all the more important that strong levels of comfort are established at this juncture. Because willy-nilly, the two countries will have much more to do with each other in the times to come.

Rising with the Sun

The two decades that witnessed such significant developments in respect of the US also saw steady progress with Japan. Challenges for India on this account were, however, very different. Unlike the US, Japan did not have a